Vitamin D and sunlight

Many Australians avoid the sun due to the threat of skin cancer. However, some exposure to sunlight is actually good for us. Read the notes below and then answer the questions.

Melanin

- Found in skin cells
- Colours our skin
- Acts as a natural barrier to **UV rays**
- Dark-skinned people have lots of melanin
- Fair-skinned people do not have much melanin

Vitamin D deficiency (also known as rickets)

- Caused by a lack of sunlight
- Leads to bones softening; children's legs can grow bent
- Common in industrial Europe centuries ago
- Occurs in Australia today in elderly populations and dark-skinned people in cold regions
- Can be cured by moderate **exposure** to sunlight

☞ **1** Why do dark-skinned people who live in cold climates often develop a vitamin D deficiency? _____

2 When babies are born their skin colour is paler than their parents. This allows babies and children to make lots of vitamin D. Why do you think this is? _____

_____

3 Are these statements true or false?

a) We can only get Vitamin D from our diets. _____

b) People with pale skin don't need any vitamin D. _____

c) Melanin protects us from UV rays. _____

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